Unit 6

Every Key

New: Five, six and seven sharps or flats; enharmonic keys (F-sharp = G-flat)

There are fifteen major keys and fifteen minor keys. You have met the keys with up to four sharps or flats; now come the rest: five, six and seven. Three pairs of them sound exactly the same and use the same keys on the piano, but are written differently: B major and C-flat major, F-sharp major and G-flat major, C-sharp major and D-flat major. Such keys are called enharmonic.

Keys with many sharps or flats look frightening, but they lie well under the hand: most of their notes are black keys, and the long fingers fall on them naturally.

What is new

The circle of fifths

Each sharp key is a fifth above the last: C, G, D, A, E, B, F-sharp, C-sharp (0 to 7 sharps). Each flat key is a fifth below: C, F, B-flat, E-flat, A-flat, D-flat, G-flat, C-flat (0 to 7 flats). Round the circle they meet: F-sharp is G-flat.

Order of sharps and flats

Sharps: F C G D A E B. Flats: B E A D G C F, the same letters backwards.

Enharmonic notes

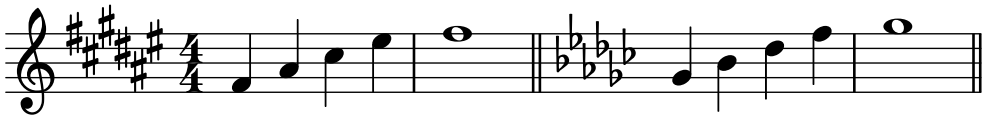
One key on the piano can have two names: F-sharp is G-flat, E-sharp is F, C-flat is B. In F-sharp major E-sharp is the 7th note; in G-flat major C-flat is the 4th.

Minor keys too

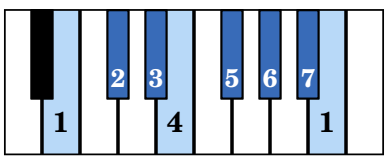
B-flat minor (five flats) and G-sharp minor (five sharps): their raised 7ths are A-natural and F-double-sharp (the white key G). A double sharp looks like a small x.

The same keys, two names

F-sharp major and G-flat major: every note sounds the same and uses the same key on the piano.

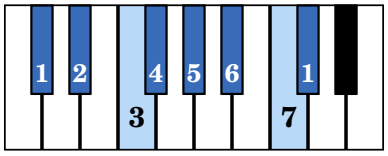


B major: five sharps



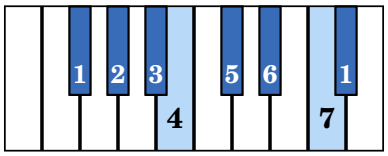
Scale degrees on the keys: B C♯ D♯ E F♯ G♯ A♯ B

D-flat major: five flats



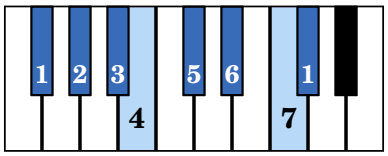
Scale degrees on the keys: D♭ E♭ F G♭ A♭ B♭ C D♭

F-sharp major: six sharps (E-sharp is the white key F)



Scale degrees on the keys: F♯ G♯ A♯ B C♯ D♯ E♯ F♯

G-flat major: six flats (C-flat is the white key B) - the same keys as F-sharp major



Scale degrees on the keys: G♭ A♭ B♭ C♭ D♭ E♭ F G♭
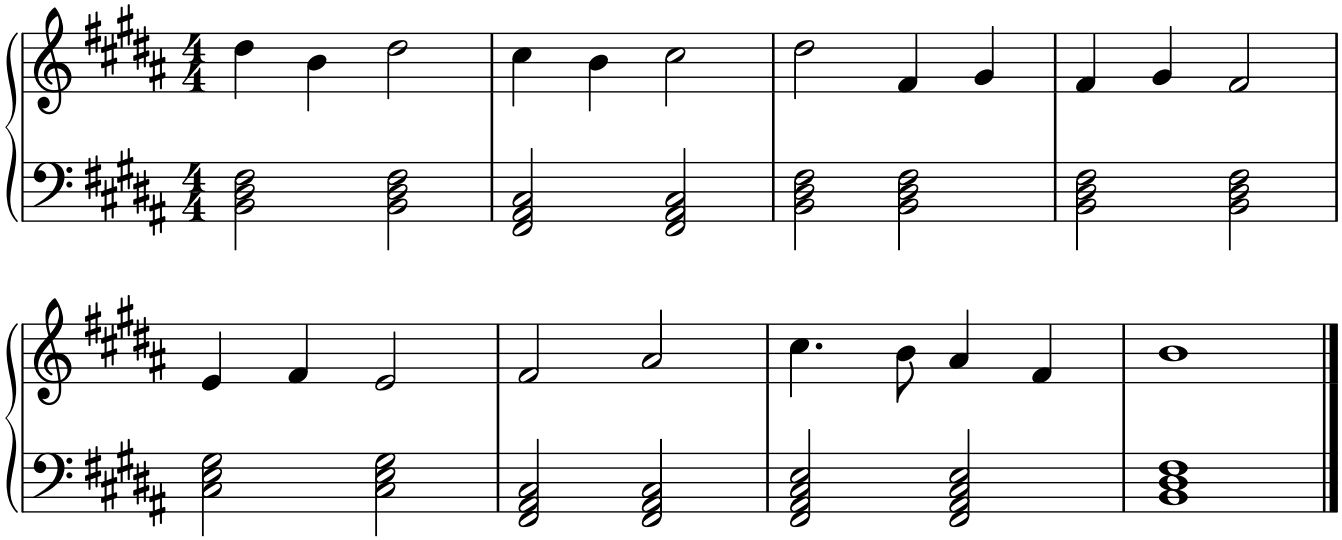
Reading tips

1. Count the sharps or flats, name the key, and say the black keys it uses before you play.
2. In five-, six- and seven-sharp or flat keys, think of the white keys as the exceptions.
3. E-sharp, B-sharp, C-flat and F-flat are white keys: read the name, find the key, and trust your hand.
4. Round the circle of fifths, each new key changes only one note: find it.
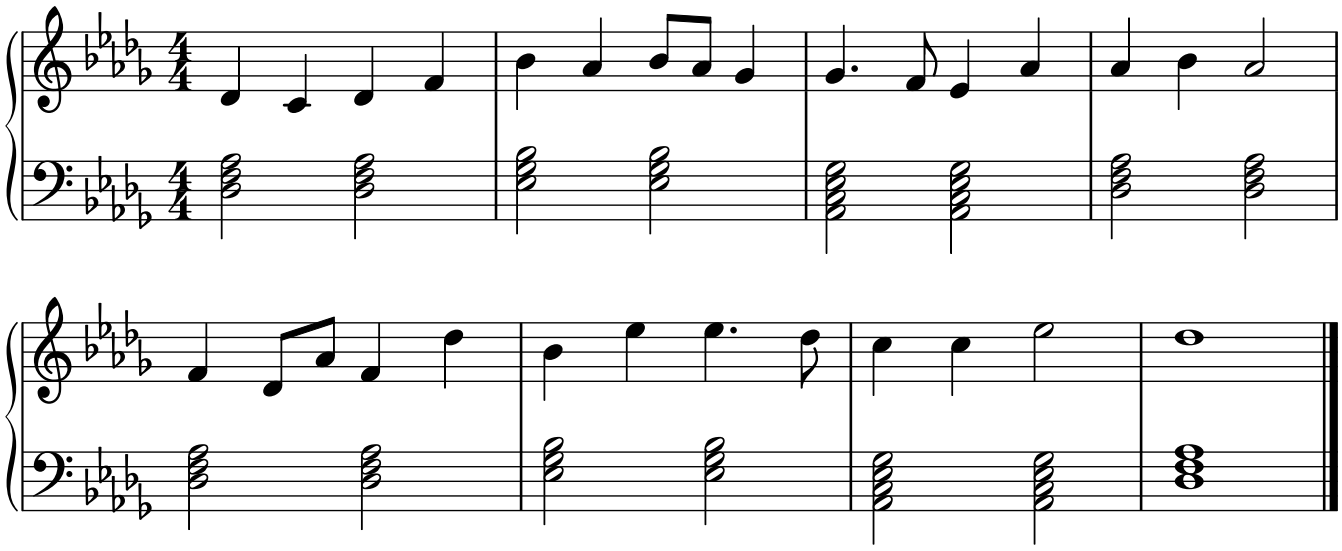
Part A: B major and D-flat major ♩ = 60

B major and D-flat major, with chords in half notes.
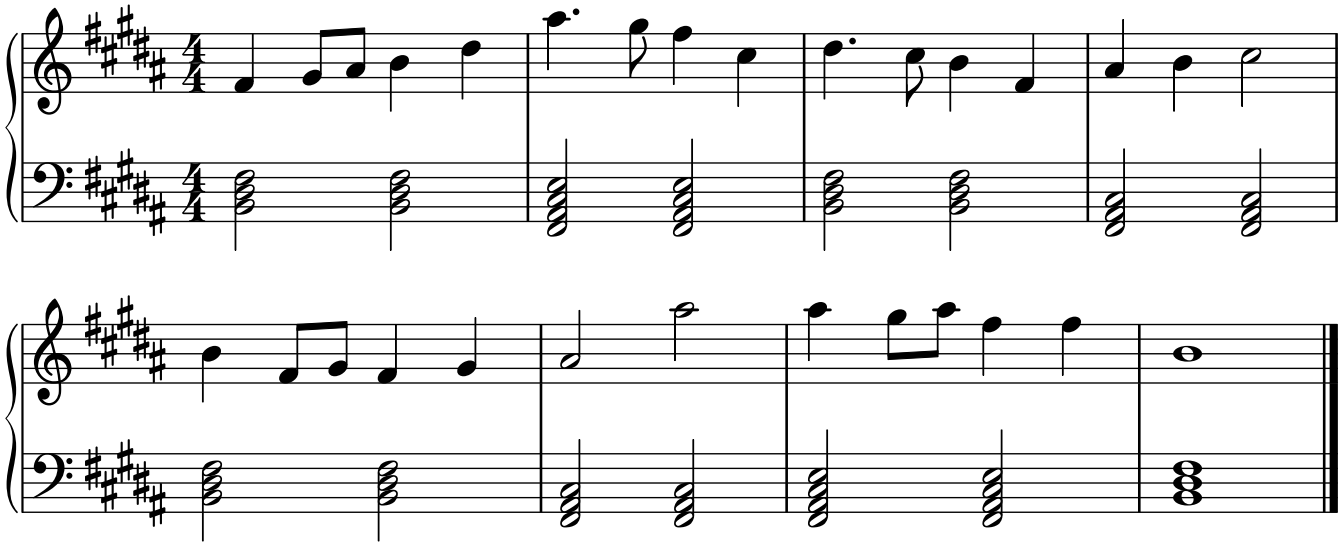
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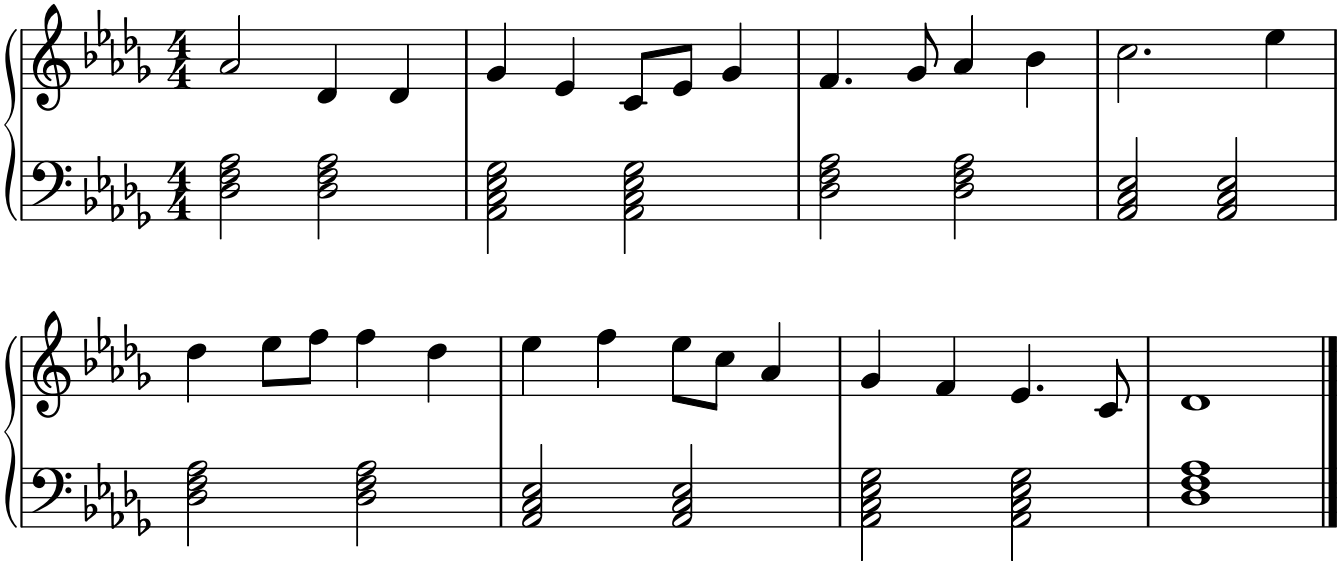


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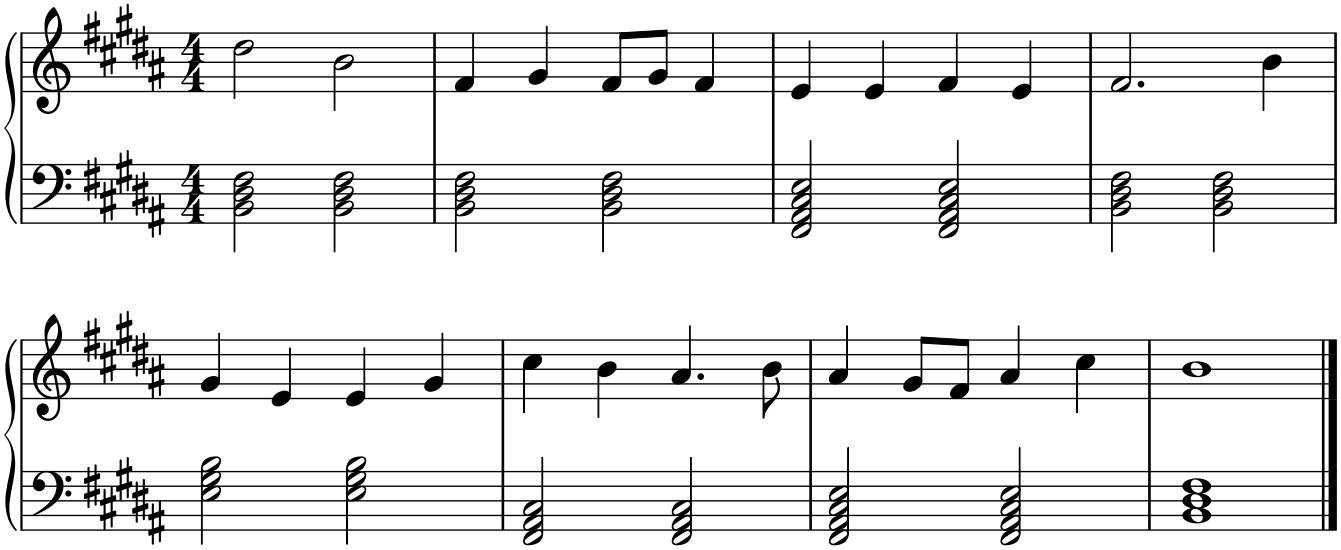


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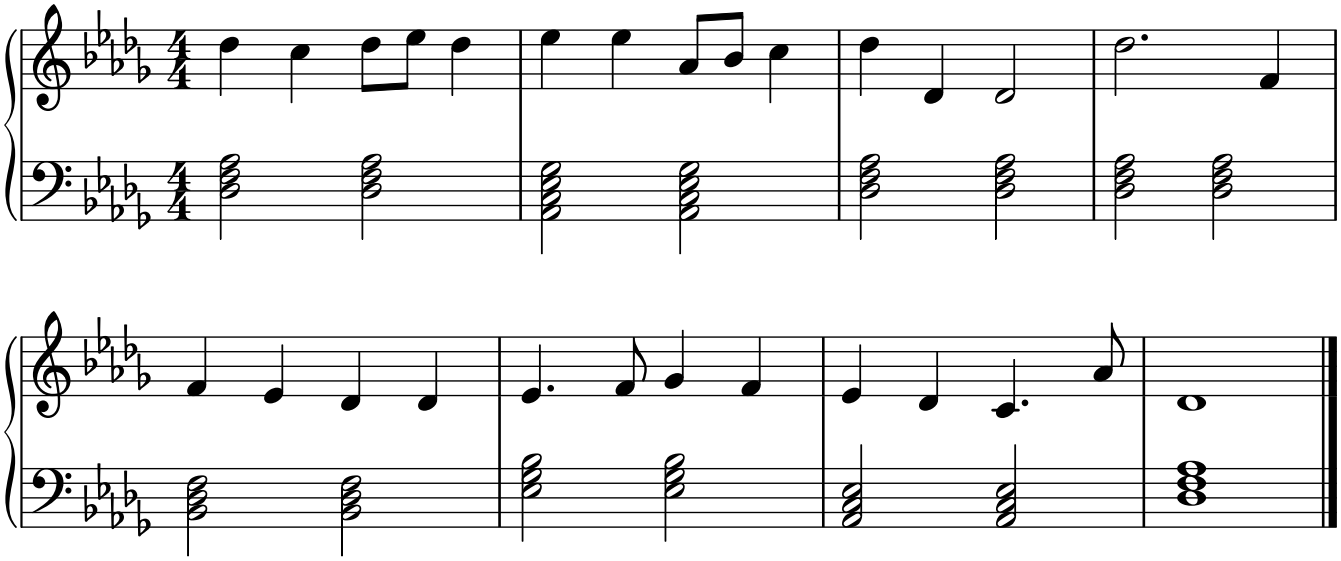


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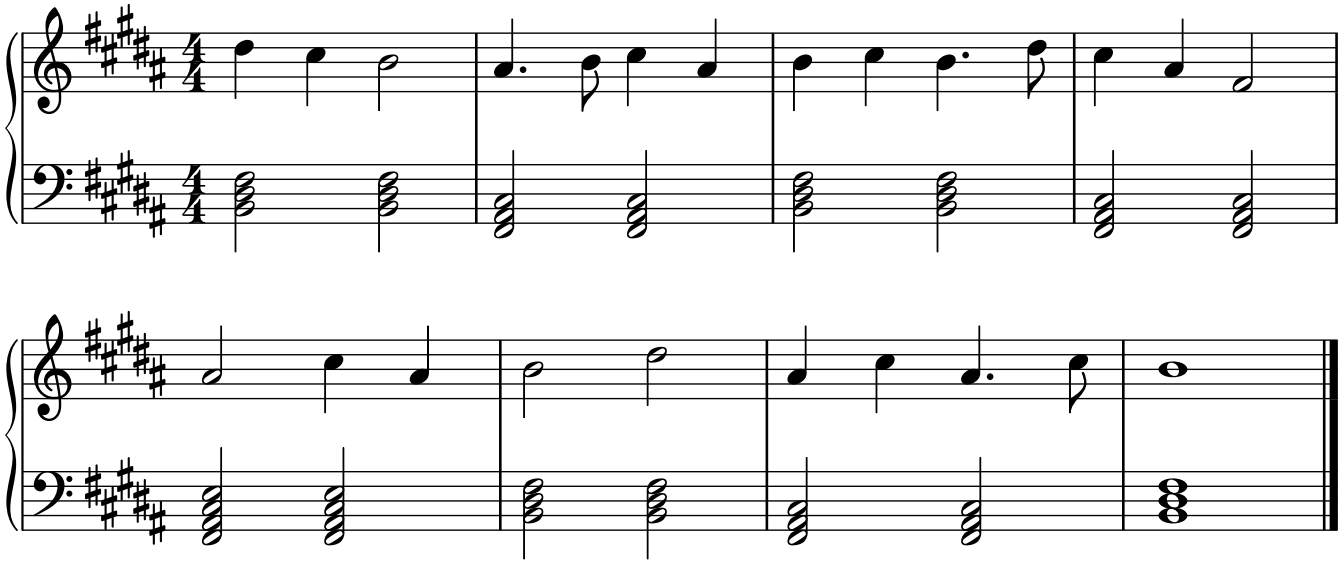


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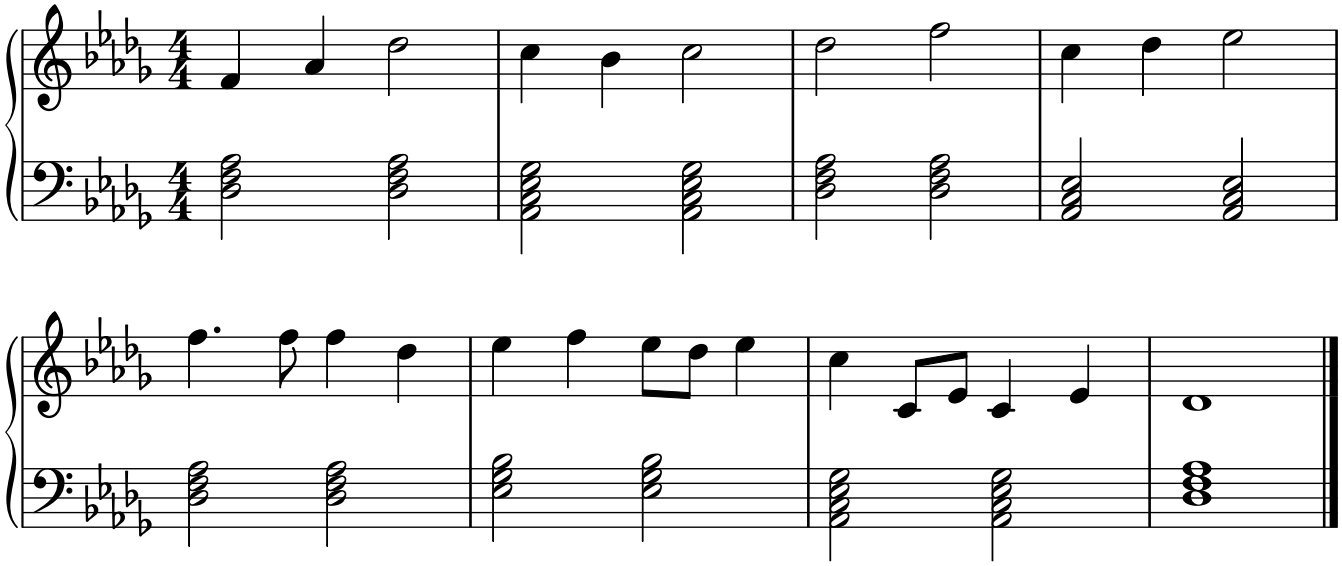


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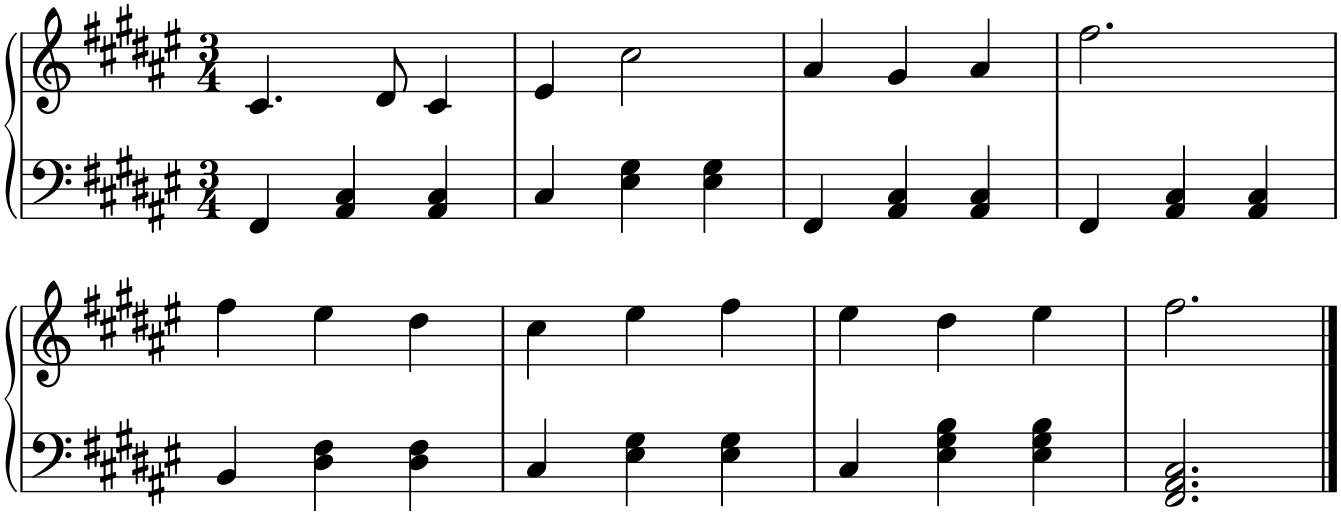


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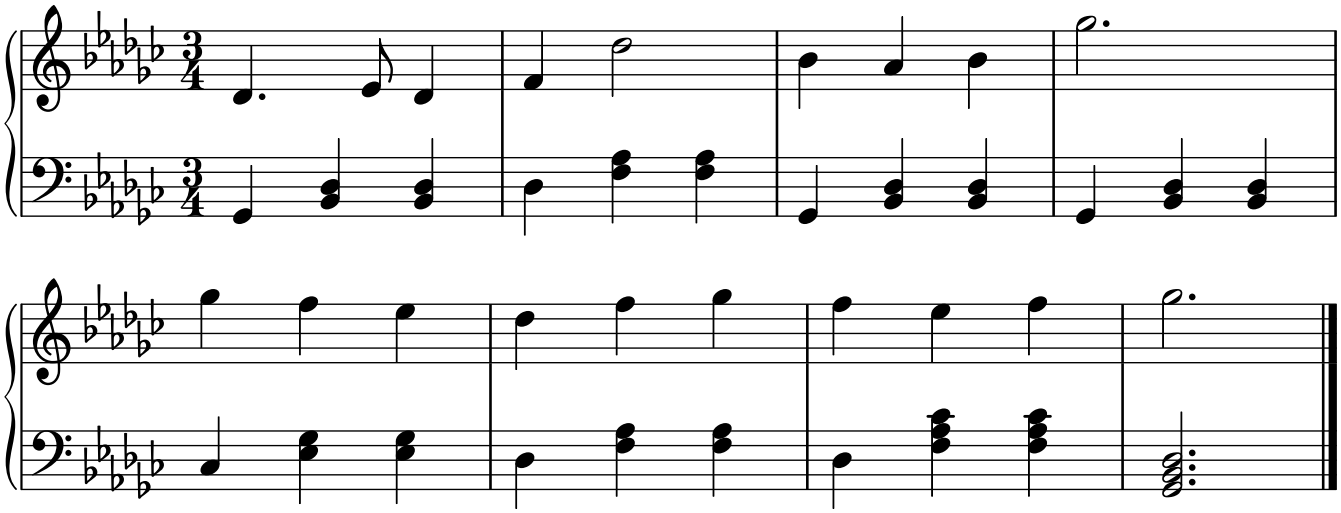


Part B: Twins, and two minor keys ♩ = 72

Twins: each F-sharp major exercise is printed again in G-flat major (a and b): play both and hear that they are the same. Between them, B-flat minor and G-sharp minor waltzes.
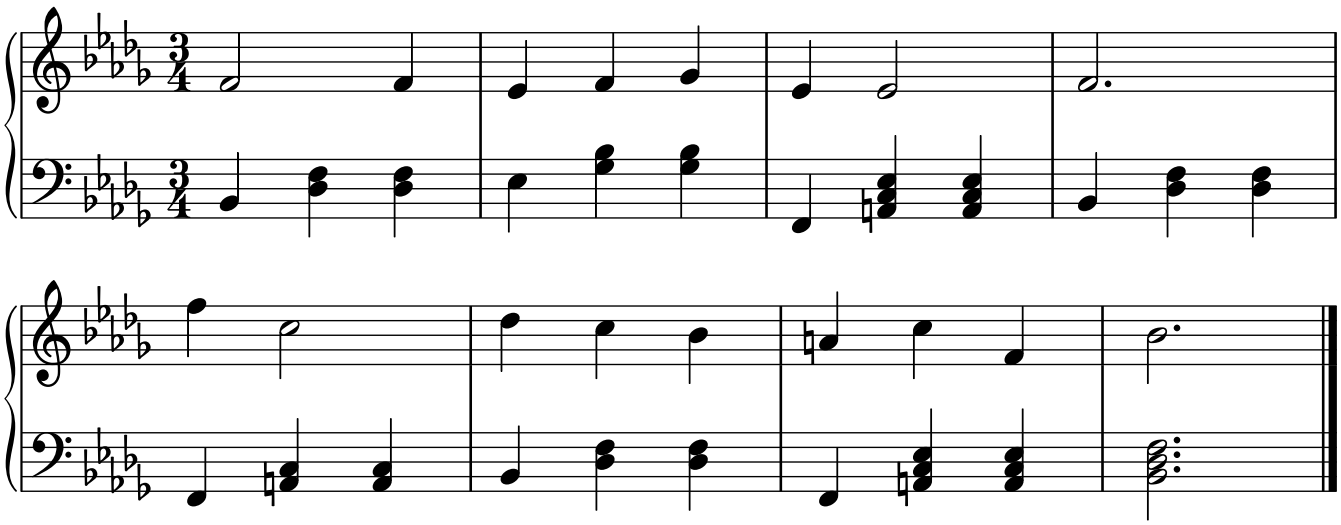
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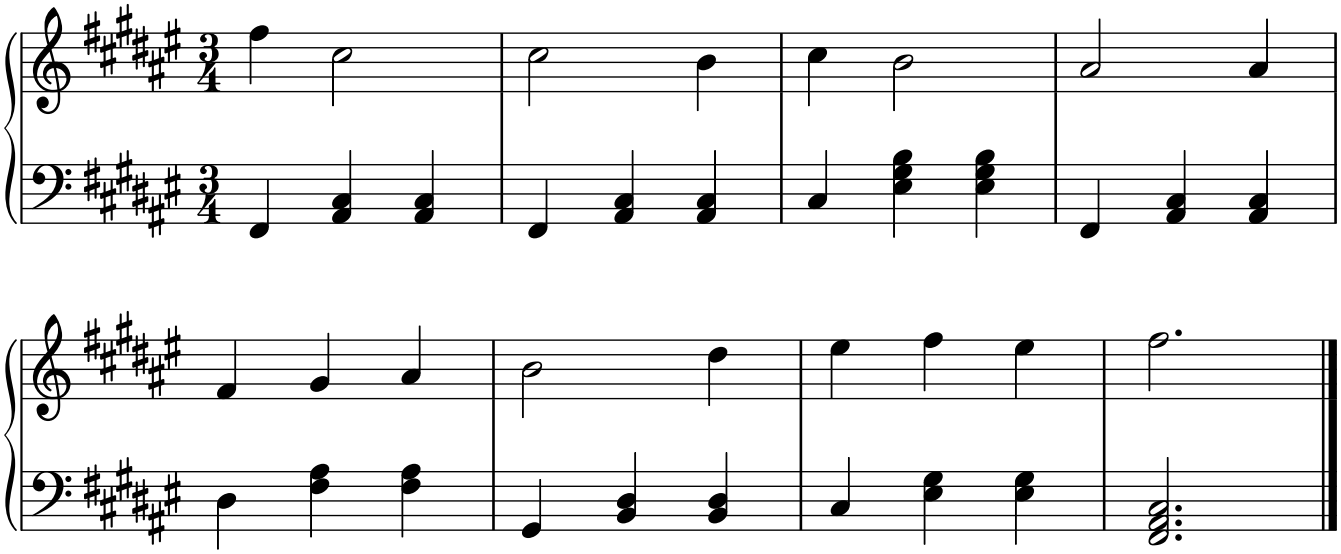


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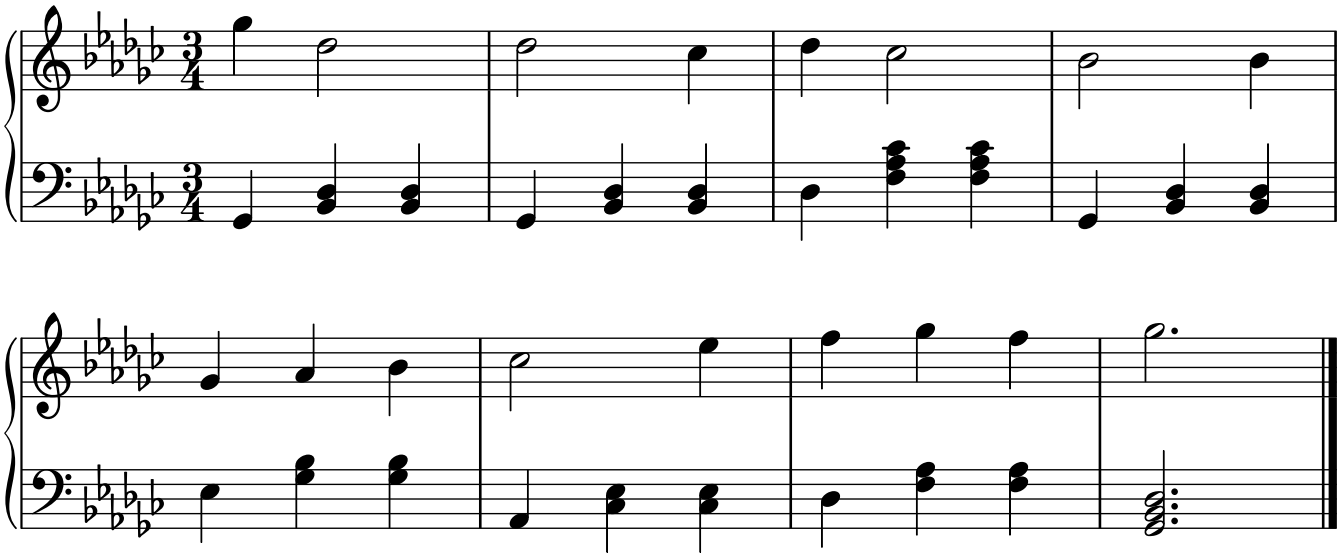


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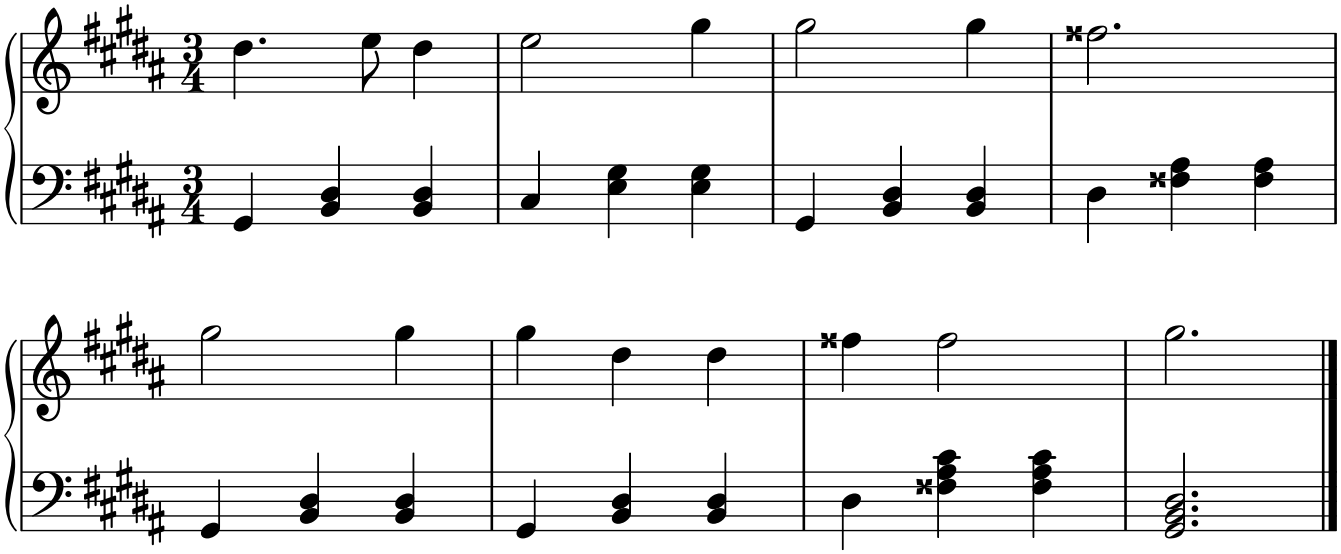


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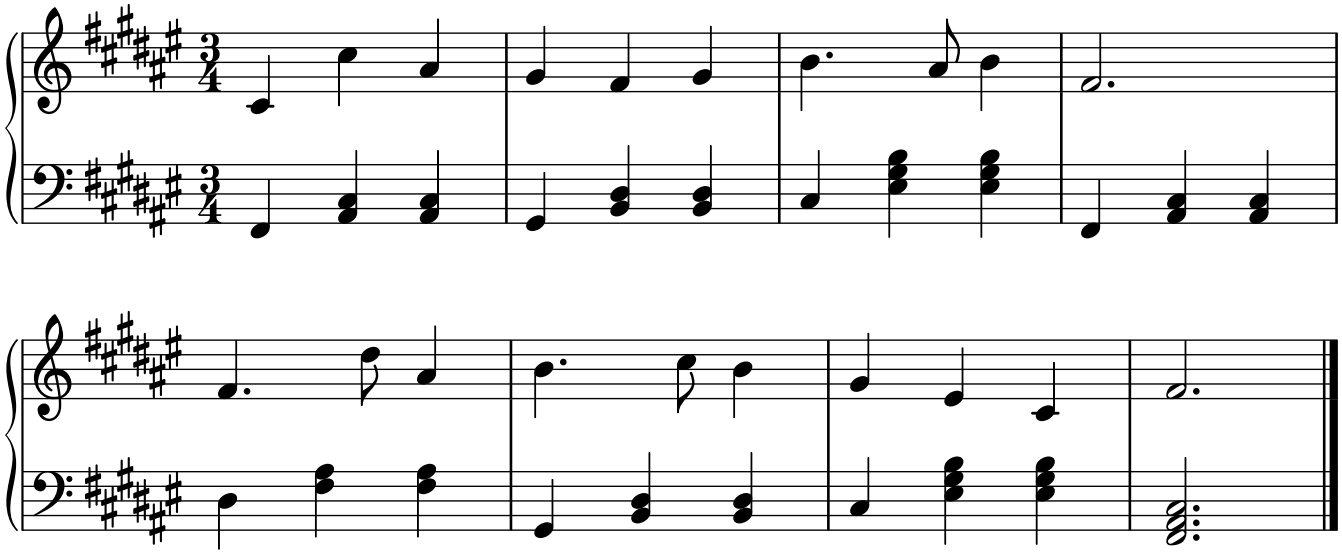


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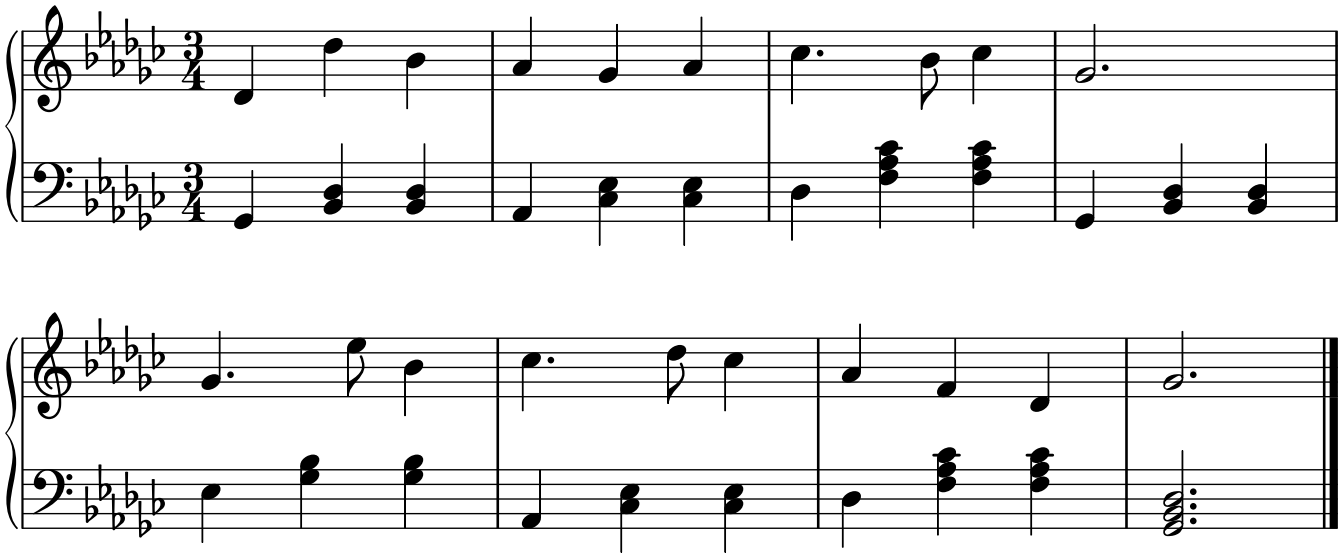


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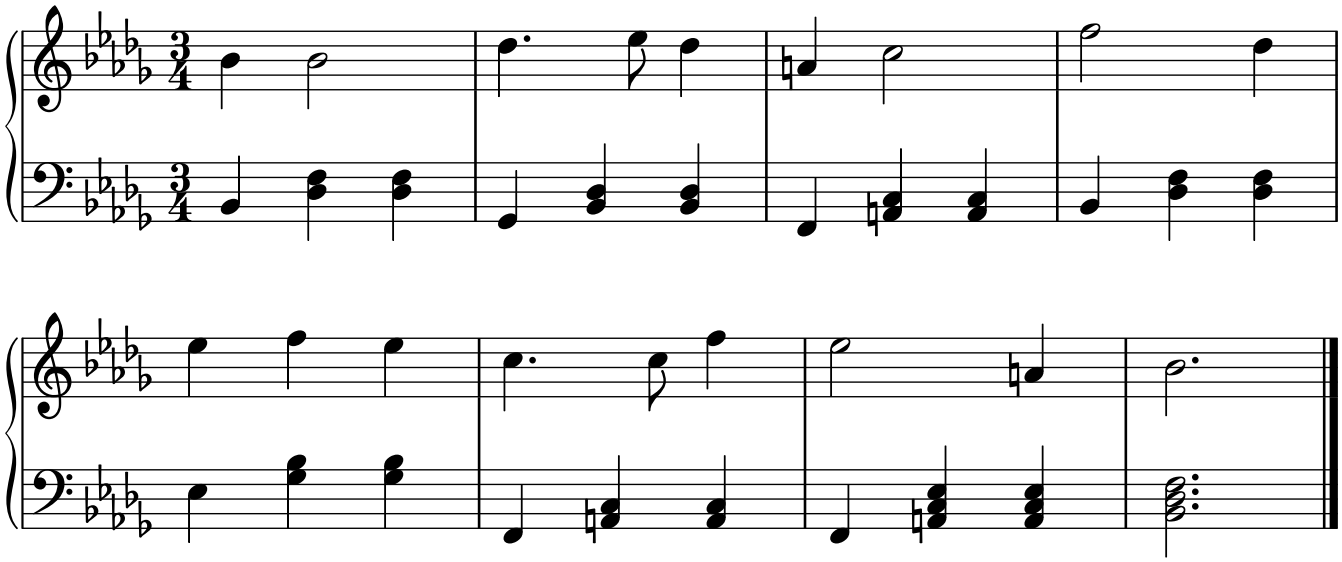


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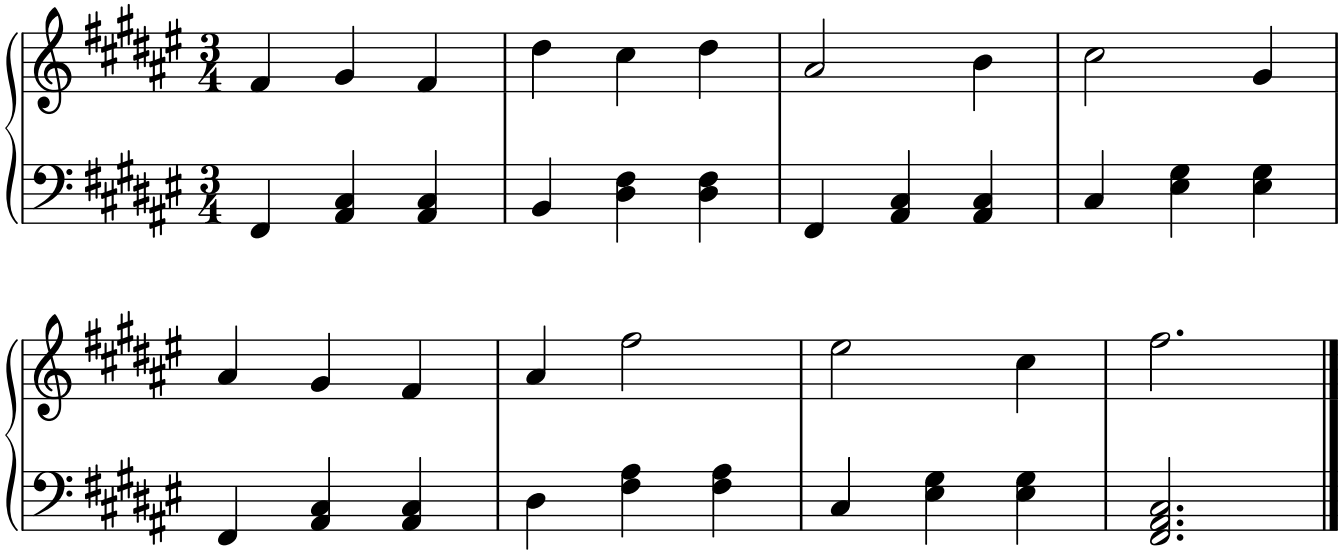


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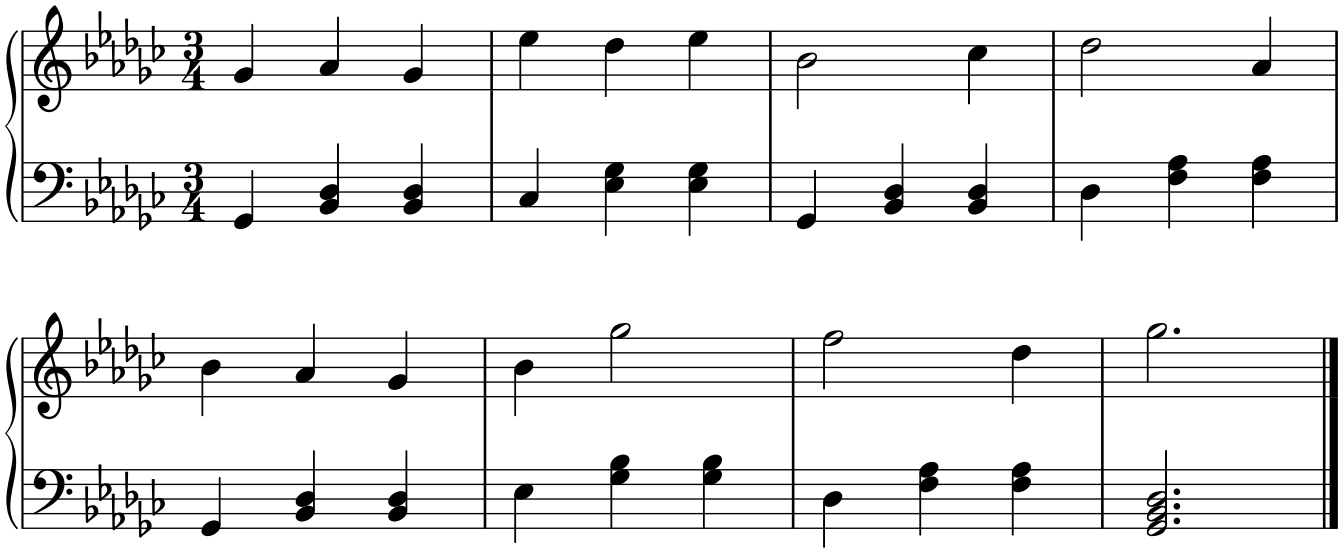


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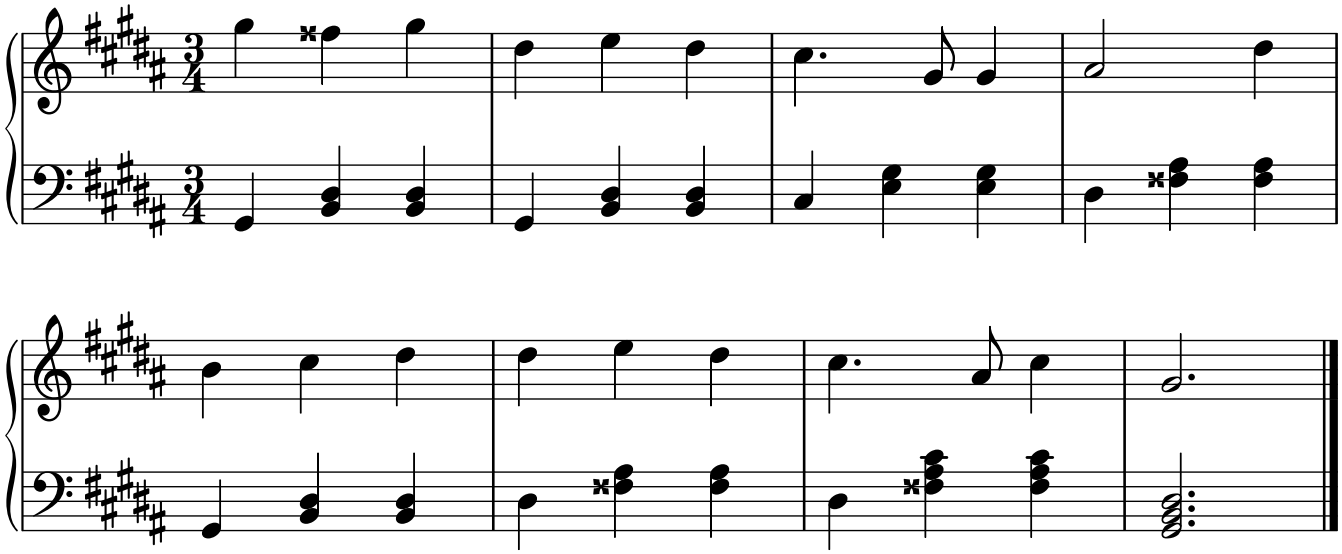


☐ **6.15a**



☐ **6.15b**



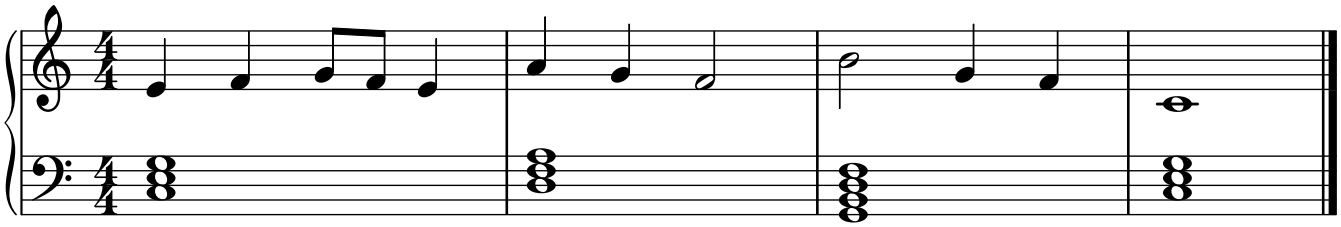
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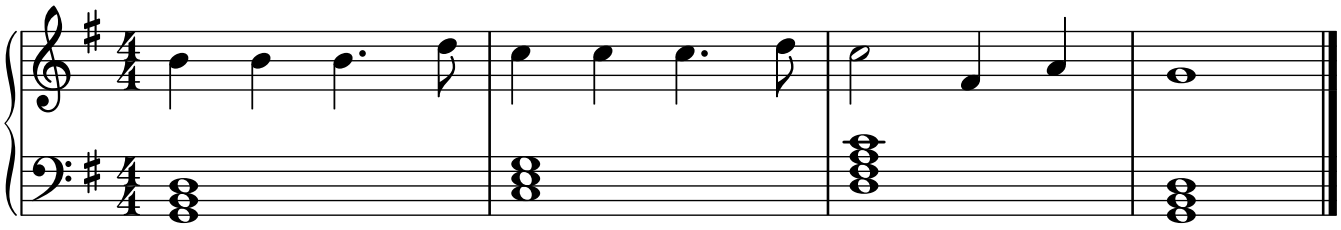
Part C: Round the circle of fifths ♩ = 60

Round the circle of fifths: each four-bar exercise is in a new key, sharps first, then flats.

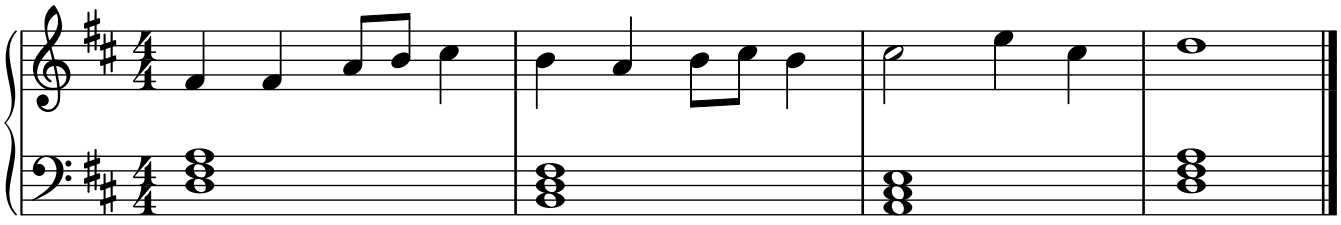
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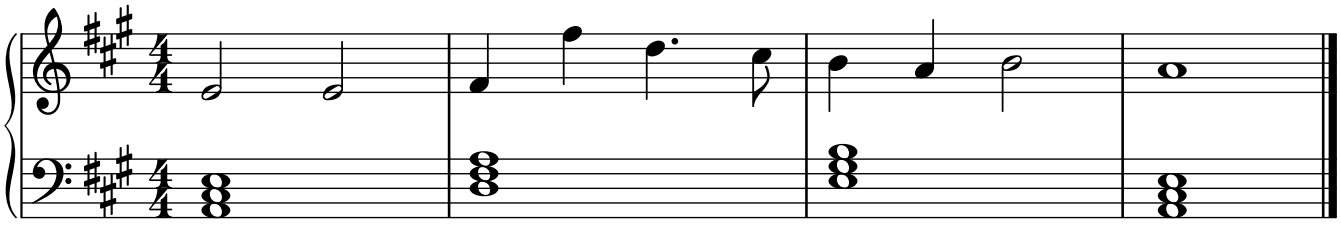
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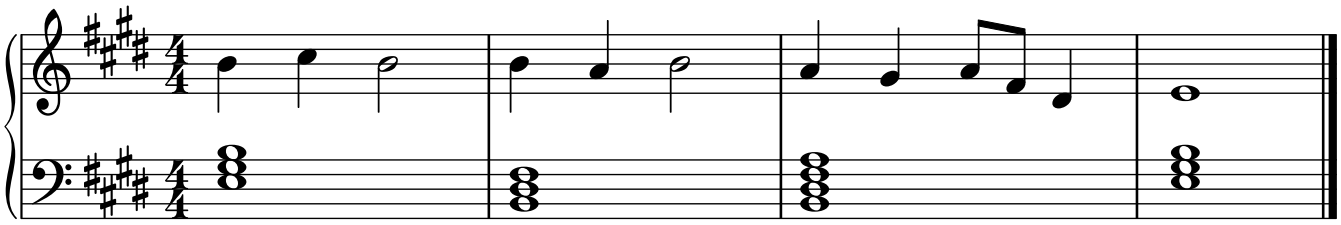
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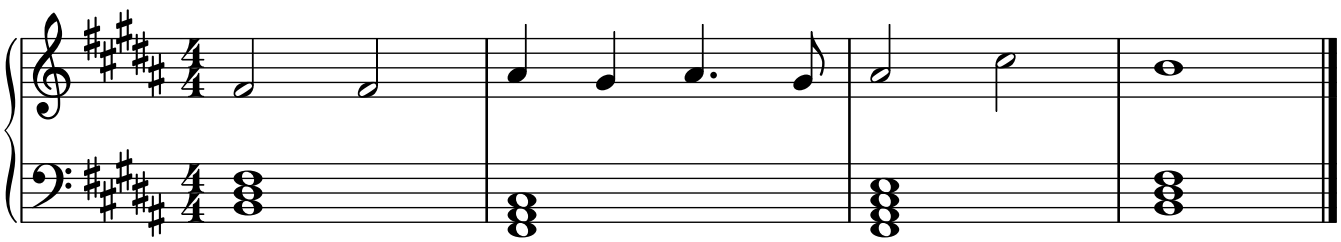
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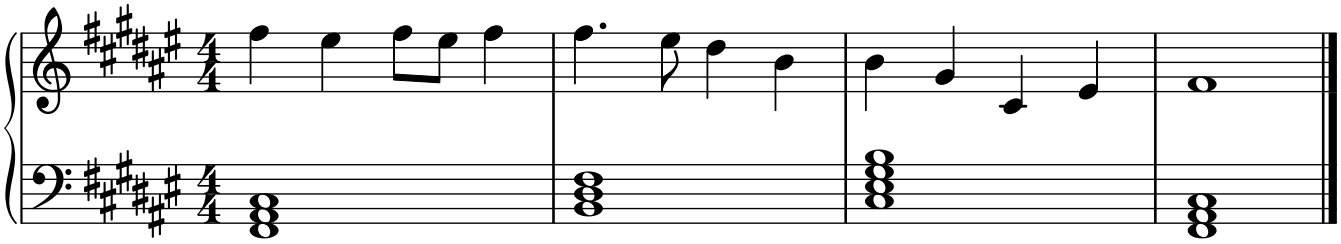
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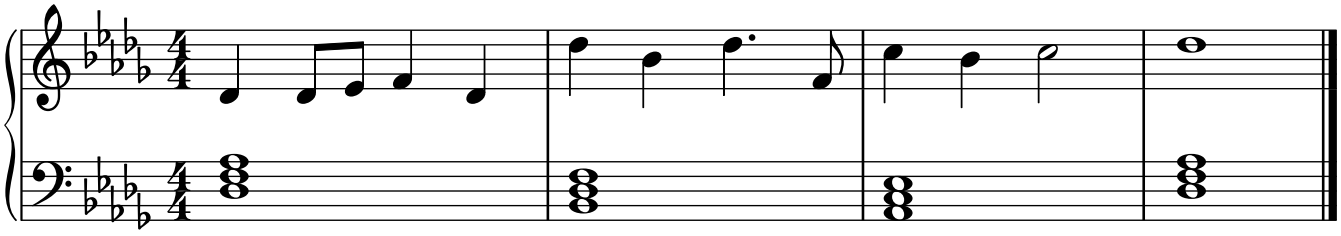
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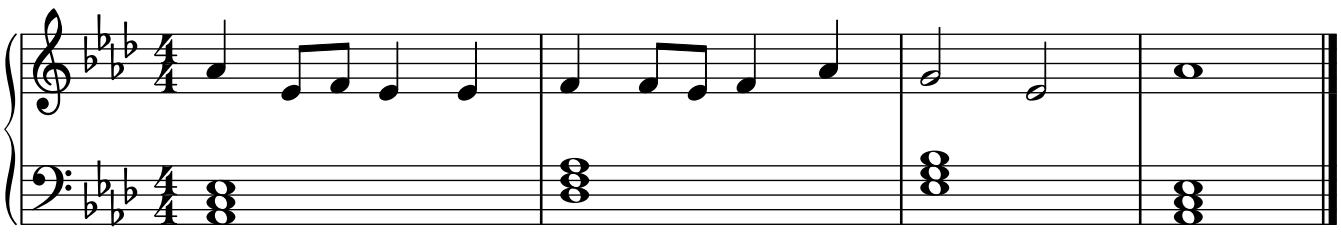
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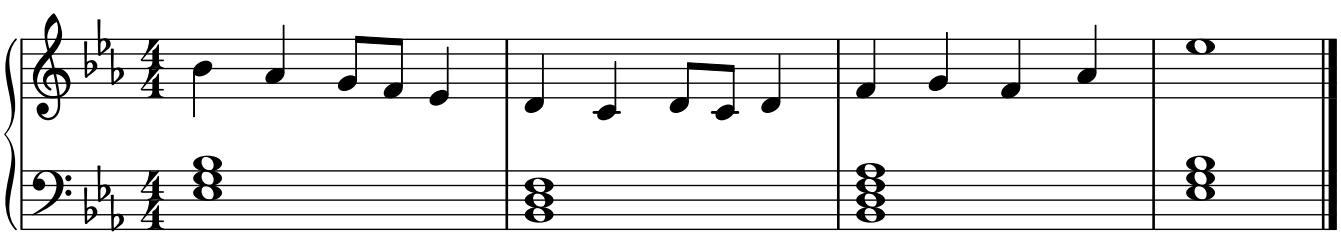
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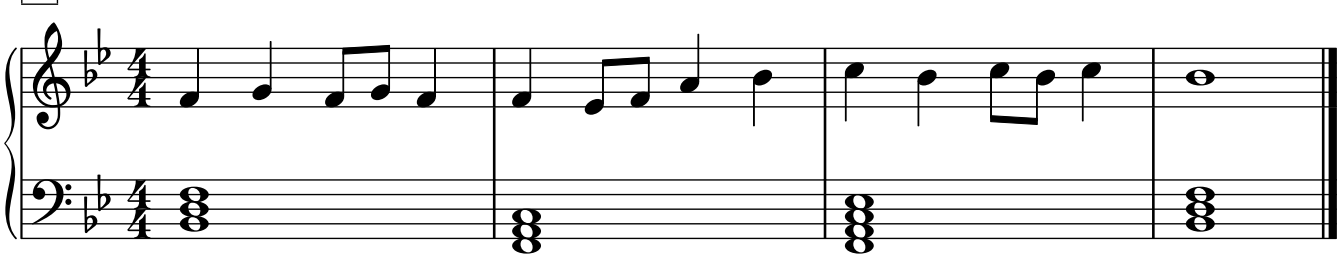


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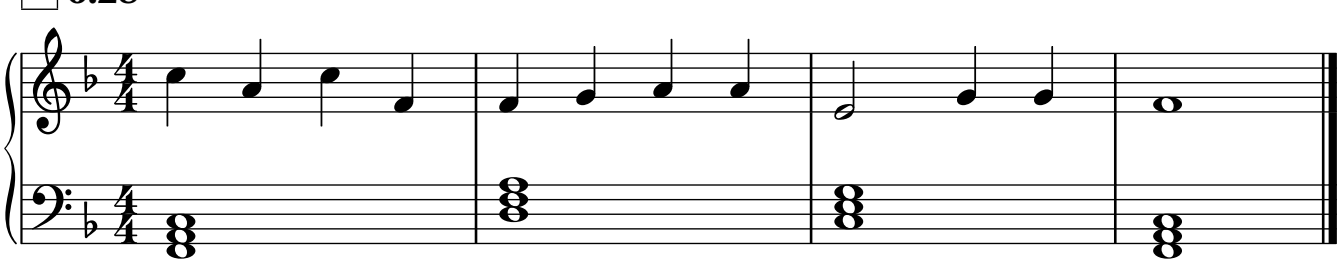
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☐ **6.27**



☐ **6.28**
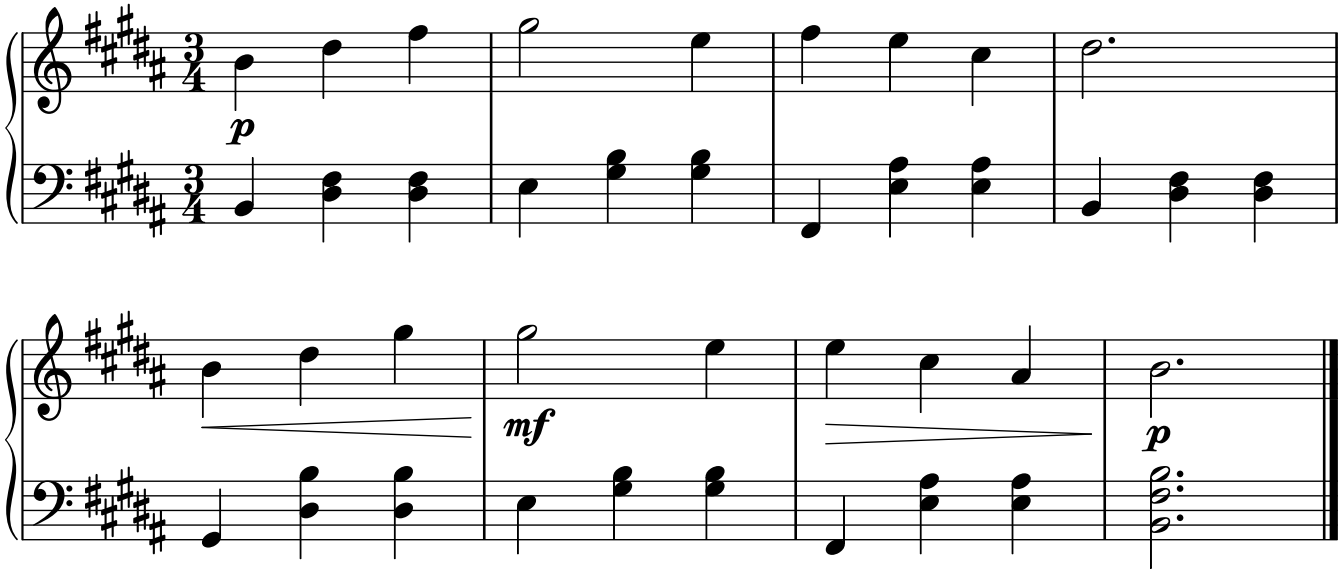


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Night Song in B ♩ = 84

Original

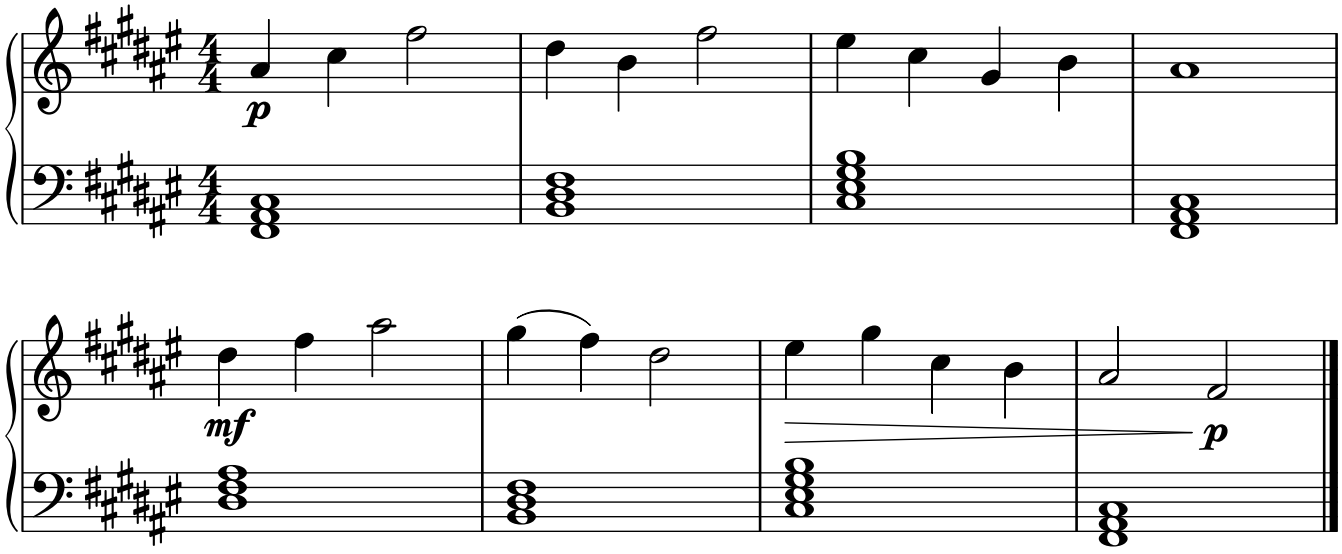
Five sharps: F, C, G, D and A. The left hand plays a waltz bass; the chords are B, E, F-sharp7 (with A-sharp) and G-sharp minor.



Enharmonic Twins (1): F-sharp major ♩ = 72

Original

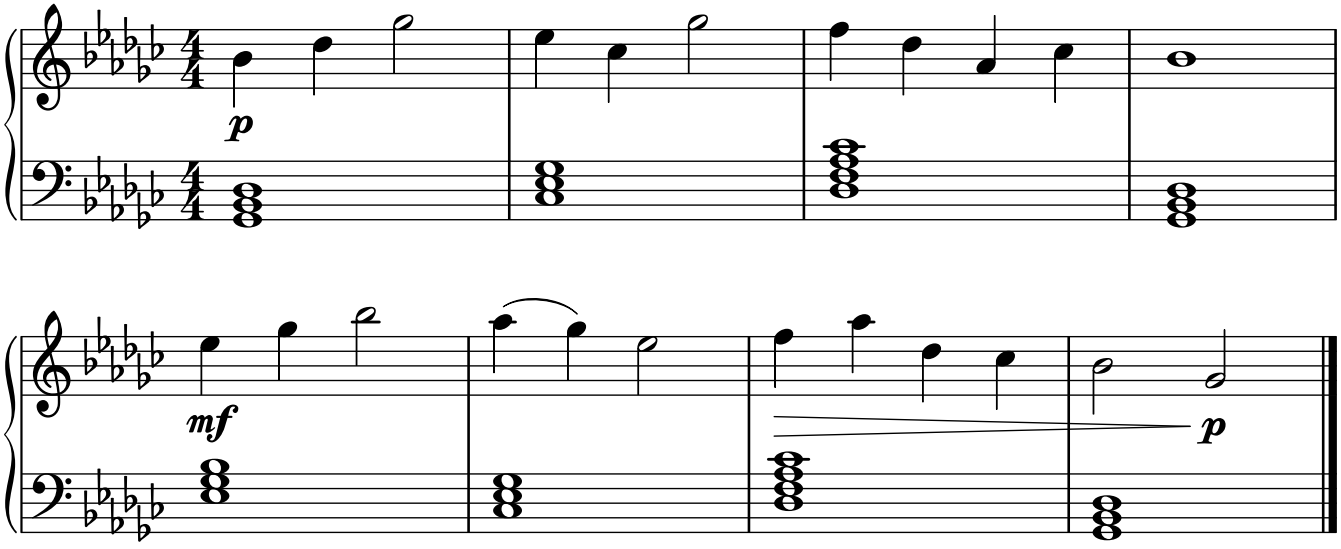
Six sharps. E-sharp (the white key F) is in the C-sharp7 chord. Play this, then the next piece: it is the same music in G-flat major.



Enharmonic Twins (2): G-flat major ♩= 72

Original

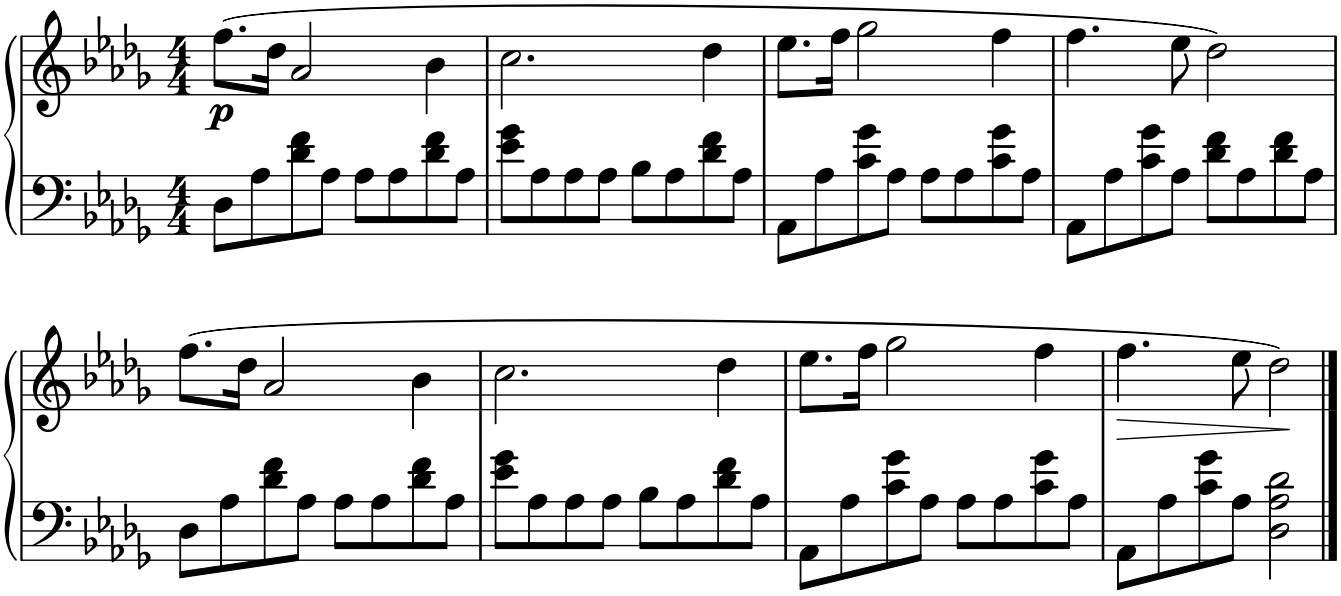
Six flats: the same keys on the piano as the F-sharp major piece, every note with a new name. C-flat is the white key B; F is in the D-flat7 chord.



Raindrop Prelude ♩= 60

Frederic Chopin (1839), Prelude in D-flat, Op. 28 No. 15 - bars 1-8, simplified
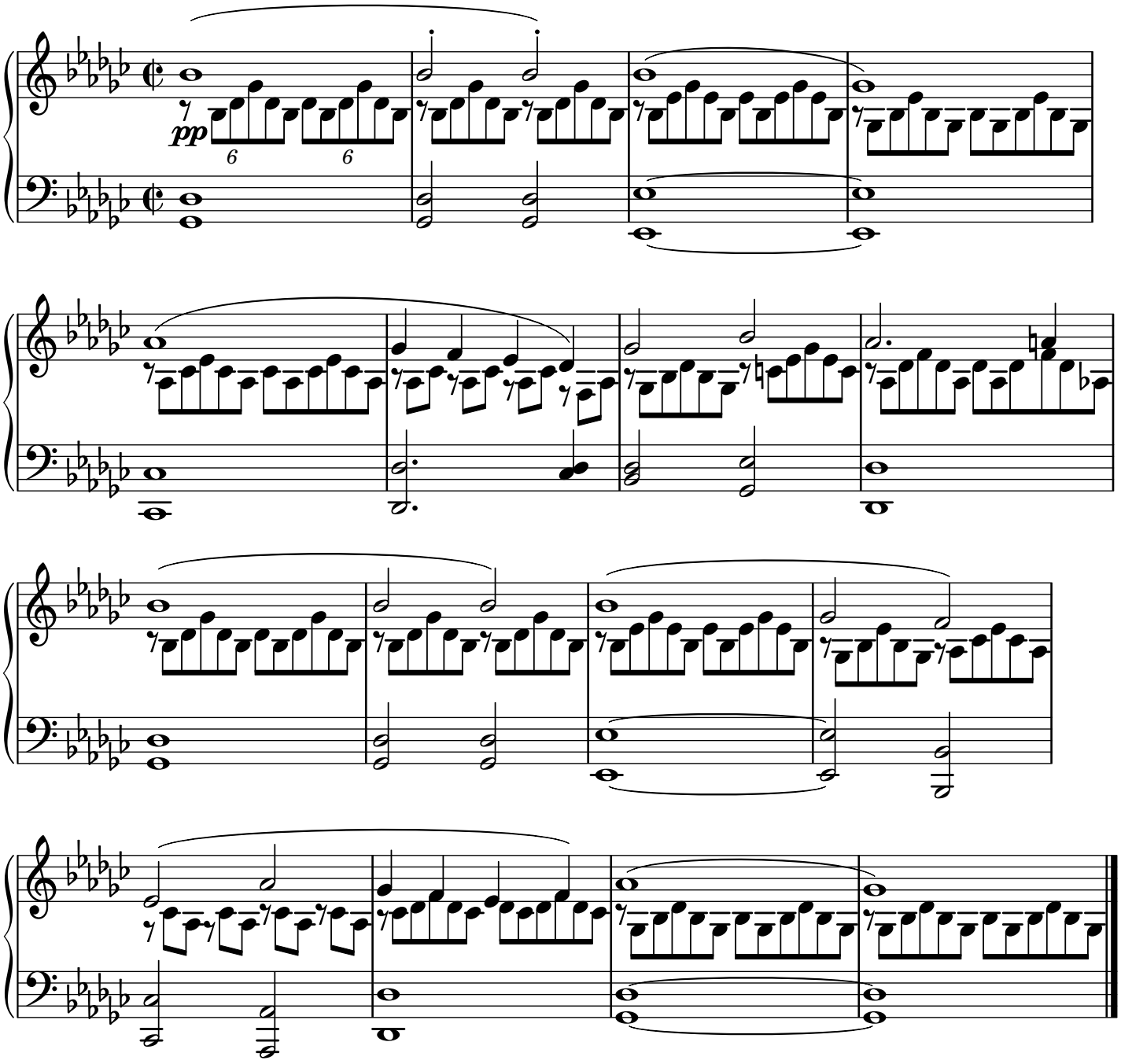
Five flats. The left hand's A-flats fall like raindrops all through the piece. Chopin's left hand has an inner voice and some notes for the right hand; here it plays the A-flats with its chords, and the ornamental run in bar 4 is left out. Chopin asks for the pedal: leave it until Unit 7. Source: Mutopia Project no. 471 (public domain).



Impromptu in G-flat ♩ = 50

Franz Schubert (1827), Impromptu, D. 899 No. 3 - the first sixteen bars, simplified

Six flats. Schubert writes four half notes in a bar (4/2); here each of his bars is split into two bars of 2/2. The right hand plays the slow tune (stems up) and a flowing accompaniment of six notes to each half note (stems down): all its eighths are triplet eighths, three to a quarter beat, though the figures 6 and 3 are printed only at the start. Count two beats in a bar. In bar 15 the hand stretches a ninth, from G-flat to the tune's A-flat. The last bar's accompaniment is a G-flat chord, so that the excerpt ends at home. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1193 (public domain).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 7?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you can name all fifteen major keys from their key signatures, round the circle of fifths.
- Pass if you can play both Enharmonic Twins at sight and hear that they are the same music.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 7.